

Rules for writing hamza

1 Introduction

The rules of how to write hamza in the Arabic script are quite complex. The matter is further complicated by the limitations of metal and digital font technology. We attempt to give a comprehensive set of rules for writing hamza and some recommendations for typographers and typesetters.

2 Scope

We treat only the orthography of Standard Arabic. The orthography of the Qurʾān (الرسم العثماني) is not discussed.

3 Seats of hamza

hamza is written in four different ways:

1. Seated on an *ʾalif*: أ or إ
2. Seated on an *wāw*: و
3. Seated on an *yāʾ*: ي
4. Unseated: ء

Here are some of notes about writing hamza in the above four methods:

- When unseated hamza comes between two letters that are joined, then it is written above the line that joins them, for example: *ḫaṭīʾah* خَطِئَةٌ. In this word, the *yāʾ* ي joins to the *tāʾ marbūṭah* ة.

As a special case, when unseated hamza comes between joined *lām* and *ʾalif* (لا), then it is positioned between them thus: لا. (In most cases, this is replaced with لآ as we will explain in the next point below.) And this is different from hamzah on the *ʾalif* following the *lām*: لآ.

- When unseated hamza is followed by an *ʾalif*: آ, the combination of hamza and *ʾalif* is usually written as *ā* as a convention. Examples: آمَنَ

‘āmana, ظَمَانٌ ḍham‘ān, شَنَانٌ shāna‘ān. However, when the ‘alif is a suffix or part of a suffix, or the hamza is doubled, or there is an ‘alif before the hamza then we will write ٱ, not ٓ. Examples: شَيَانٌ shay‘āni, سَأَلْ sa‘āl, قِرَاءَاتٌ qirā‘āt.

- When hamza is seated on ‘alif, if it has an *kasrah*, it is written below the ‘alif: اِ. Otherwise, it is written above the ‘alif: اُ, أُ, أُ.
- When hamza is seated on yā’ ي the dots of the yā’ are no longer written. Here’s how it will appear in different positions:

Isolated	End	Middle	Beginning
ئ	ى	ي	ي

Note that hamza is seated on yā’ in the middle position ي is different from unseated hamza between two joining letters ي.

So how do we know when to write hamza unseated and when seated? And how do we choose between its three different seats? There are a set of rules that we need to follow in order to correctly write hamza.

4 Rules for determining the seat of hamza

4.1 Without prefixes and suffixes

We will first learn how to determine the seat of hamzah for a word without any prefix or suffix.

Hamzah can occur in three positions in a word:

1. At the beginning of the word
2. In the middle of the word
3. At the end of the word

We will treat each of these positions below.

4.1.1 At the beginning of the word

When hamza occurs in the beginning of a word, then:

- a. If the hamza carries a long-ā vowel, it is written unseated followed by an ‘alif and written as ٓ, for example ٓأَمَنَ ‘āmana.
- b. If the hamza carries any other vowel, it is written seated on an ‘alif, and is marked with the appropriated vowel mark, for example ٱسْلَمَ aslama, أُورِدُ uridu, ٱسْلَامٌ islām, ٱيْمَانٌ imān, أُؤْخَذُ ūkhidha.

4.1.2 In the middle of the word

The most general case is when hamza is in the middle of a word.

Arabic has three short vowels, three long vowels, two diphthongs, and a *sukūn*. Each of these has an order of precedence and a hamza seat.

Precedence	Vowel	Seated hamzah
1.	<i>ī/ay</i>	ء
2.	<i>i</i>	ئ
3.	<i>ū/aw</i>	ء
4.	<i>u</i>	ؤ
5.	<i>ā</i>	ء
6.	<i>a</i>	أ
7.	◌ْ	ء

Main rule: Disregard any doubling mark ّ and consider the vowel on the consonant before the hamza and the *shortened* vowel on the hamza itself. Determine which of the two vowels wins by being higher in precedence in the above table. The winning vowel's seat will be the seat of the hamza.

Sub-rule: If the main rule determines that hamza is to be seated on 'alif, and there is a long *ā* vowel on the hamza using an 'alif, then hamza shall be unseated. And the combination of ٱ will usually be written as ٱ.

Examples:

Word	Vowel on consonant before hamza	Shortened vowel on hamza	Winning vowel	Seated hamza
هَيْئَة <i>hay'ah</i>	<i>ay</i>	<i>a</i>	<i>ay</i>	ء
خَطِيئَة <i>khaṭi'ah</i>	<i>ī</i>	<i>a</i>	<i>ī</i>	ء
اِسْتِيَّاس <i>'isti'ās</i>	<i>ī</i>	<i>a</i>	<i>ī</i>	ء (Exception: ٱ is not written as ٱ when the preceding vowel is <i>ī</i> .)
تَوَّام <i>taw'am</i>	<i>aw</i>	<i>a</i>	<i>aw</i>	ء
سَائِل <i>sā'il</i>	<i>ā</i>	<i>i</i>	<i>i</i>	ئ
تَسَاوُل <i>tasā'ul</i>	<i>ā</i>	<i>u</i>	<i>u</i>	ؤ
تَسَاءَل <i>tasā'ala</i>	<i>ā</i>	<i>a</i>	<i>ā</i>	ء
قِرَاءَات <i>qirā'āt</i>	<i>ā</i>	<i>a</i>	<i>ā</i>	ء

Word	Vowel on consonant before hamza	Shortened vowel on hamza	Winning vowel	Seated hamza
نَوَان <i>nū'ānun</i>	ū	a	ū	ء
مَسْئُول <i>mas'ul</i>	◌ْ	u	u	وْ
تَرْئِيس <i>tar'is</i>	◌ْ	i	i	ئْ
مِرْأَة <i>mir'āh</i>	◌ْ	a	a	ء (Using sub-rule.)
ظَمَان <i>ḍham'an</i>	◌ْ	a	a	ء (Using sub-rule.)
مَسْأَلَة <i>mas'alah</i>	◌ْ	a	a	أْ
الْمِرْأَة <i>almar'ah</i>	◌ْ	a	a	أْ
بَيْس <i>bi'sa</i>	i	◌ْ	i	ئْ
سُؤْل <i>su'l</i>	u	◌ْ	u	وْ
كَاس <i>ka's</i>	a	◌ْ	a	أْ
سُؤْلَة <i>su'ila</i>	u	i	i	ئْ
يَيْس <i>ya'isa</i>	a	i	i	ئْ
رَيْس <i>ra'is</i>	a	i	i	ئْ
سُؤَال <i>su'al</i>	u	a	u	وْ
رُؤُوس <i>ru'ūs</i>	u	u	u	وْ
لُؤْي <i>lu'ayy</i>	u	a	u	وْ
شَنَان <i>shana'an</i>	a	a	a	ء (Using sub-rule.)
سَأَل <i>sa'ala</i>	a	a	a	أْ
رَأَى <i>ra'a</i>	a	a	a	أْ (Sub-rule doesn't apply because ā vowel at end represented by ئْ, not 'alif.)
رَأْس <i>ra'asa</i>	a	a	a	أْ
يُرْئِيس <i>yura'isu</i>	a	i	i	ئْ
رُئِيس <i>ru'isa</i>	u	i	i	ئْ
تَفْؤُول <i>tafa'ul</i>	a	u	u	وْ
سَأَل <i>sa'al</i>	a	a	a	ء (Using sub-rule.)

Word	Vowel on consonant before hamza	Shortened vowel on hamza	Winning vowel	Seated hamza
لَّال <i>laʔāl</i>	<i>a</i>	<i>a</i>	<i>a</i>	ء (Using sub-rule.)

4.1.3 At the end of the word

When hamza occurs at the end of a word, disregard the vowel on hamza itself, and consider only the vowel on preceding consonant. Plug it into the precedence table as above to determine the seat of hamza.

Word	Vowel on consonant before hamza	Seated hamza
دُعَاءُ <i>duʔāʔu</i>	<i>ā</i>	ء
سُوءٌ <i>sūʔu</i>	<i>ū</i>	ء
جِيءَ <i>jiʔa</i>	<i>i</i>	ء
ضَوْءٌ <i>ḍawʔa</i>	<i>aw</i>	ء
شَيْءٌ <i>shayʔa</i>	<i>ay</i>	ء
بُطْءٌ <i>buṭʔu</i>	◌ْ	ء
عِبْءٌ <i>ʿibʔu</i>	◌ْ	ء
شَطْءٌ <i>shaṭʔu</i>	◌ْ	ء
يُهَدِّىْ <i>yuhaddiʔu</i>	<i>i</i>	ئ
سَيِّىْ <i>sayyiʔu</i>	<i>i</i>	ئ
بَطْءٌ <i>baṭʔu</i>	<i>u</i>	و
يَهْدَأُ <i>yahdaʔu</i>	<i>a</i>	أ
مُبْتَدَأٌ <i>mubtadaʔi</i>	<i>a</i>	إ

The exception to this rule is when the previous letter is a doubled *wāw* with an *ḍammaḥ*. In this case the hamza will again be unseated. Example تَبَوُّءٌ *tabawwuʔu*.

Note also that مُبْتَدَأٌ *mubtadaʔi* can be written with the hamza below the *ʾalif* because of the *i*-mark on the hamza. But it is also common to write it as مُبْتَدَأٌ *mubtadaʔ*, especially when the hamza is unvoiced.

4.2 Prefixes and suffixes

4.2.1 Prefixes

If hamza is in the beginning of a word, adding a prefix to the word will not alter the writing of the hamza. Examples:

- لِ + أُسْتَاذٍ = لِأُسْتَاذٍ
- اَلْ + آخِرَةٌ = الْآخِرَةُ

4.2.2 Suffixes

If hamza is at the end of a word, adding a suffix to the word can, in general, alter the writing of the hamza. Hamza is now, generally, treated as if it is in the middle of the word, and the rules for hamza in the middle of a word apply. Examples:

Word	Vowel on consonant before hamza	Shortened vowel on hamza	Winning vowel	Seated hamza
بَرِيْثُونِ <i>bari'ūna</i>	<i>ī</i>	<i>u</i>	<i>ī</i>	ء
بَرِيْثَانِ <i>bari'āni</i>	<i>ī</i>	<i>a</i>	<i>ī</i>	ء
بَرِيْثِيْنَ <i>bari'ina</i>	<i>ī</i>	<i>i</i>	<i>ī</i>	ء
بَرِيْثِيْنَ <i>bari'ayni</i>	<i>ī</i>	<i>a</i>	<i>ī</i>	ء
شَيْثُهُ <i>shay'uhu</i>	<i>ay</i>	<i>u</i>	<i>ay</i>	ء
شَيْثُهُ <i>shay'ahu</i>	<i>ay</i>	<i>a</i>	<i>ay</i>	ء
شَيْثُهُ <i>shay'ihī</i>	<i>ay</i>	<i>i</i>	<i>ay</i>	ء
شَيْثَانِ <i>shay'āni</i>	<i>ay</i>	<i>a</i>	<i>ay</i>	ء
شَيْثِيْنَ <i>shay'ayni</i>	<i>ay</i>	<i>a</i>	<i>ay</i>	ء
مَجِيْثُهُ <i>maji'uhu</i>	<i>ī</i>	<i>u</i>	<i>ī</i>	ء
مَجِيْثُهُ <i>maji'ahu</i>	<i>ī</i>	<i>a</i>	<i>ī</i>	ء
مَجِيْثُهُ <i>maji'ihī</i>	<i>ī</i>	<i>i</i>	<i>ī</i>	ء
سُوْثُهُ <i>sū'ihī</i>	<i>ū</i>	<i>i</i>	<i>i</i>	ئ
دَوْثُهُ <i>daw'ihī</i>	<i>aw</i>	<i>i</i>	<i>i</i>	ئ

Word	Vowel on consonant before hamza	Shortened vowel on hamza	Winning vowel	Seated hamza
سُوْهُ <i>sū'uhu</i>	<i>ū</i>	<i>u</i>	<i>ū</i>	ء
سُوْهُ <i>sū'ahu</i>	<i>ū</i>	<i>a</i>	<i>ū</i>	ء
سُوْءَانِ <i>sū'āni</i>	<i>ū</i>	<i>a</i>	<i>ū</i>	ء
دَوْءُ <i>ḍaw'ahu</i>	<i>aw</i>	<i>a</i>	<i>aw</i>	ء
دَوْءَانِ <i>ḍaw'āni</i>	<i>aw</i>	<i>a</i>	<i>aw</i>	ء
مُتَّكِيْنِ <i>muttaki'īna</i>	<i>i</i>	<i>i</i>	<i>i</i>	ئ
يُبَرِّئُونِ <i>yubarrī'ūna</i>	<i>i</i>	<i>u</i>	<i>i</i>	ئ
يُبَرِّئُونِ <i>yubarra'ūna</i>	<i>a</i>	<i>u</i>	<i>u</i>	ؤ

There are some exceptions:

- If the letter before the hamza has a *sukūn* and is not *wāw* or *yā'*, then the hamza will be written unseated. Examples:

- جُزْءَانِ *juz'āni*
- عِبْرَانِ *ʿib'āni*
- عِبْرَيْنِ *ʿib'ayni*
- بَطْءُ *buṭ'ahu*
- بَطْءُ *buṭ'uhu*
- بَطْءُ *buṭ'ihī*

- If the hamzah is after a long-*ū* vowel or an *aw* semi-vowel, and the hamzah does not have an *i*-mark, then it is written unseated. Examples:

- يَسُوْءُونِ *yasū'ūna*

This is actually an acceptable variant in the general case, as will discuss below in section @ref(hamza-variants)

(ان, هـ, and هـ are suffixes.) Note that the combination اء is not written as آ when the 'alif is part of the suffix.

4.3 *tanwīn* on final hamza

tanwīn on a final hamza does not affect the writing of the hamza except in the case of *tanwīn al-fatḥ*. When writing *tanwīn al-fatḥ* on a hamza at the end of a word:

1. If there is an 'alif before a unseated hamza اء, then we don't add a silent 'alif when writing *tanwīn al-fatḥ*. For example دَاء becomes دَاء dā'an, not دَاء.
2. Otherwise, we add the silent 'alif after the hamza so that the hamza is now in the middle of the word with a suffix 'alif after it. We now pretend that the hamza has an *fatḥaḥ* and that the 'alif after it is a long-ā vowel. Then we go through the rules for writing hamza in the middle of a word (given above) to determine how hamza will be written. We then write the *an*-mark on the hamza. Examples:

- مبتدأ becomes مبتدأ, مبتدأ, مبتدأ
- ملجأ becomes ملجأ, ملجأ, ملجأ
- جزء becomes جزء, جزء, جزء
- شيء becomes شيء, شيء, شيء
- سي becomes سي, سي, سي
- تبوء becomes تبوء, تبوء, تبوء

4.4 Variants

There are some historical and regional variants to the above rules. The main one is when the letter before hamza has a *sukūn*, the hamza is generally written unseated. So with this variant, we write:

- مسؤول instead of مسؤول
- أسئلة instead of أسئلة
- مسألة instead of مسألة

However, this rule appears to be not consistently followed. For example, *nash'ah* is generally always written نَشَاءَ never نَشَّاءَ.

A second variant is to avoid the repetition of vowel letters like و and ي. So they write:

1. رُؤُوس instead of رُؤُوس.
2. رِئِيس instead of رِئِيس.

5 Typographical limitations

Due to what appears to have been a limitation of typesetting technology in the days of typewriters, metal typography, and early digital typography, unseated hamza between two joining letters ء was usually written as seated on *yā'* instead: ء. Because of this limitation we are now accustomed to seeing:

- شَيْئًا instead of شَيْئًا
- خَطِيئَةً instead of خَطِيئَةً
- هَيْئَةً instead of هَيْئَةً
- عِبْنَيْن instead of عِبْنَيْن

and similar variants.

These variants have pervaded to such a degree that many modern explanations on the rules of hamza orthography present the above as the correct way of writing, and modify their rules with exceptions to allow this writing.

Fortunately, advancements in digital font technology now allow us to revert back to the original rules. However, unfortunately, only very few computer fonts today actually implement this feature.

Two fonts, of which we are aware, that do allow the preferred orthography are:

1. “Amiri”: <https://www.amirifont.org/>
2. DecoType “Naskh”: <https://www.decotype.com/oneliner/>

With these “hamza-safe fonts” you can always use U + 0621 “Arabic Letter Hamza” to type unseated hamza no matter whether it is between joining or non-joining letters. With most other fonts U + 0621 “Arabic Letter Hamza” will prevent the surrounding two letters from joining.

This issue has been discussed in detail by Thomas Milo in Unicode L2/14-109: <https://unicode.org/L2/L2014/14109-inline-chars.pdf>.

However, the problem remains that this is a font-specific hack. It seems that the Unicode has no official guidance in this regard.

Another solution, that works with most other fonts, is to fake the correct orthography using a combination of U + 0640 “Arabic Tatweel” and U + 0654

“Arabic hamza above” thus ٲ to achieve the appearance of unseated hamza between two joining letters. However, this will not work when hamza is between *lām* and ‘*alif*’ in the mandatory *lām-‘alif*’ ligature ٲ (correct: ٲ, incorrect: ٲ). Such words are rare in Standard Arabic but do exist, e.g. ٲ *la’āl* meaning “pearl-seller”, and ٲ. Perhaps the official solution ought to be that fonts absorb the tatweel and not let it affect the *lām-‘alif*’ ligature when it is input between *lām* and ‘*alif*’.

Beware that using tatweel in this manner may also affect the searching of characters in a digital document.